shipping enterprise. Unlike Scindia's promoters who rubbed shoulders with prominent national leaders, VOC's connections were rather modest.

If the origins of the idea are unknown VOC's objectives and ambitions are even less clear. Did he believe that the Swadeshi shipping effort could be scaled up and become an all-India enterprise? What was his assessment of the strength of the national bourgeoisie? Was it big enough to plunge into this capital-intensive business and dethrone the global behemoths of BI and P&O? Did he really expect Indians to venture into shipbuilding and develop dockyards? Would the colonial state keep quiet? Or for that matter the British mercantile interests? At this distance in time and given the lack of sources we can hardly speculate on these matters.

But VOC's zeal was real. Police intelligence, the press, judicial records and private correspondence show that he almost single-handedly launched SSNCo and steered it to political, even if not commercial, success.

Initially, VOC rallied the merchants of Tuticorin when many of them harboured misgivings and feared the wrath of the government. The shipping venture would not have sailed in the first instance if he had mishandled the tantrums of the original promoter, S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai. In converting the Swadeshi firm into a joint-stock limited company, he not only gave vision to the company—the company's prospectus, marrying business with politics, has his definitive signature—but also directed the drafting of its founding documents. If mobilizing the local merchants was an achievement, roping in some big names lending prestige to the enterprise also redounds to his credit. Bringing Pandithurai Thevar on board as the president of the company was a brilliant move. Not only did Pandithurai Thevar add heft to the company, he also steadied the ship in VOC's absence, balancing conflicting interests. That he continued to invest in the company even as it was sinking speaks for the confidence that VOC commanded in Pandithurai Thevar.

Inducting the venerable C. Vijayaraghavachari, despite his initial reluctance, was another excellent move. VOC virtually conscripted him as a legal advisor though his ultimate role was much larger—as director, arbiter and negotiator with the colonial state and BI. Not only did